had gone on a holiday to New York and stayed with his father's friend, Arthur S. Lall, an Indian diplomat and scholar who was India's representative at the United Nations in the 1950s. Though Ratan admits that this visit 'strengthened his desire to go [to] the US', he says: 'I wanted to live in the US before I ever went [to New York].' Commenting on this visit, he says: 'It was as though I had always been there. It was a strange thing, though. [I] had absolutely no sense of having to adapt, and that reinforced my view as to where I wanted to go for college.' But for Naval Tata, there was no place better than England for a youngster to pursue his education. However, Ratan got his grandmother to support him in going to the US. She settled the issue, avowing, 'If he wants to go there, he should go there.'

Studying in Riverdale

In the 1950s, Indian students could not directly secure admission to US colleges. It was mandatory to clear the US College Board examinations first. In July 1954, five months short of his seventeenth birthday, Ratan boarded a TWA Constellation flight in the middle of the night to take him to the country he would come to call his second home. From Idlewild (now John F. Kennedy) Airport in New York, Ratan took a taxi to his college-preparatory school, Riverdale Country School in the northwest part of The Bronx. Established in 1907, Riverdale was a renowned educational institution; amongst the school's famous alumni was President John F. Kennedy. It was both a day and boarding school, and Ratan took up residence in the latter. Its principal, John Haydn Jones, emphasized the need to inculcate in children constructive competition with a social bias. He underlined the necessity to 'stretch minds' and instil a belief in putting the 'other fellow first'—two qualities that would give the 'best chance for personal happiness and social usefulness'. These are values that Ratan holds sacrosanct.

School was interesting, and Ratan adjusted rather quickly to life as a boarder. The initial days, however, were not without their share of anxieties. Living in an alien land with its new culture and ways made him homesick. But to his credit, he soon overcame this and melted into the new environment, enjoying the American way of life. The academic rigour at the school was high. The syllabus was demanding. Ratan confides that